IMPLEMENTATION PLAN — BASED ON EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

CafeBook — What to Build, When to Build It

A practical guide: what the Executive Summary recommends vs. what CafeBook already has

Source: Café Seat-Booking App Executive Summary **Current Build:** Working single-cafe MVP **Date:** May 2026

CONTEXT What the Executive Summary Recommends

The Executive Summary covers a **global-scale platform** serving hundreds of cafés. CafeBook is currently a **working single-café tool**. The gap between the two is not a problem — it is a roadmap. This document filters the Executive Summary into what is *relevant now*, what comes *next*, and what can wait.

✓ Already Built in CafeBook

- Online booking interface — date, time, party size
- Zone-based seat selection (6 zones)
- Customer accounts with secure login (JWT)
- Admin dashboard — view, filter, update bookings
- Table management — add, toggle, delete
- Booking status workflow (Pending → Confirmed → Done)
- Role-based access control (ADMIN / GUEST)
- Real-time availability query — no double-booking
- BCrypt password hashing — secure storage

✗ What the Summary Says Is Missing

- Email / SMS confirmations and reminders
- Payment gateway for deposits (Stripe)
- Password reset flow
- Waitlist / virtual queue
- Analytics dashboard (peak times, no-show rates)
- Interactive floor plan / seat map
- Loyalty / rewards programme
- POS integration (Toast, Square)
- Multi-café / multi-location support
- GDPR consent + data deletion features
- Cloud hosting — currently local machine only
- WebSocket real-time live updates

PRIORITIES Every Missing Feature — Ranked by Priority

#	Feature	Priority	Why It Matters	When
1	**Email confirmation on booking**	CRITICAL	Customers do not trust a booking without a confirmation email. Reduces cancellation calls to staff. Exec Summary lists this as MVP Core.	NOW
2	**Password reset via email**	CRITICAL	Users who forget passwords are permanently locked out. No recovery = users abandon the platform and never return.	NOW
3	**Cloud hosting (move off local machine)**	CRITICAL	Right now only the person running the app on their laptop can serve customers. No real café can use it remotely. Must fix before any commercial use.	NOW
4	**GDPR — data consent & deletion**	CRITICAL	Legal requirement in UK/EU. Users must be able to request their data be deleted. Without this, taking real customers is a legal risk. Exec Summary flags this explicitly.	NOW
5	**SMS reminder 24h before booking**	HIGH	Exec Summary states this directly reduces no-shows. Industry data: reminders cut no-shows by ~30%. Biggest single ROI improvement	NEXT

			for café owners.	
6	**Stripe deposit on booking**	HIGH	Competitors like Tock win on this. A £2–£5 deposit eliminates casual no-shows. Exec Summary lists payment gateway as MVP Core. Also enables subscription billing.	NEXT
7	**Analytics dashboard for admins**	HIGH	Exec Summary lists this as a key selling point. "Peak hours, zone popularity, no-show rate" — this data is what café owners pay for. Already have all the data in the DB, just need charts.	NEXT
8	**Waitlist when fully booked**	HIGH	Exec Summary and all major competitors include this. When a slot opens up, the next person on the list gets notified automatically. Turns lost customers into recovered bookings.	NEXT
9	**Multi-café / multi-location support**	MEDIUM	Without this, only one café can ever use the platform. It's the unlock for scale and chain customers. Exec Summary includes chain pricing tier at £150/month. Significant code change required.	NEXT
10	**Interactive floor plan / seat map**	MEDIUM	Visual seating beats a dropdown list. Customers can see the actual layout and pick their exact spot. Competitors like SevenRooms use this as a premium feature. Good differentiator.	LATER
11	**Loyalty / rewards programme**	MEDIUM	Exec Summary lists this as optional-later. Increases repeat visits. "Book 5 times, earn a free coffee." Keeps customers returning and reduces competitor switching.	LATER
12	**WebSocket real-time availability**	MEDIUM	Exec Summary recommends WebSockets for live seat updates. Currently two users could race to the same seat. Needed before high-traffic cafés use the platform.	LATER
13	**POS integration (Toast / Square)**	FUTURE	Exec Summary lists this as integration. High value but complex — links bookings to orders. Only relevant after the platform has paying customers who use Toast/Square POS.	LATER
14	**Calendar sync (Google / iCal)**	FUTURE	Nice-to-have — customers see bookings in their calendar. Listed in Exec Summary as basic integration. Low revenue impact but improves customer experience.	LATER
15	**Microservices & Redis cache**	FUTURE	Exec Summary recommends this for scale (hundreds of cafés, thousands of bookings/second). Current Spring Boot monolith is fine up to ~50 cafés. Only refactor when traffic actually demands it.	LATER

ROADMAP Build in This Order — Phase by Phase

PHASE 1 — Do Right Now (0–6 weeks)

- **Email confirmation** — SendGrid free tier, triggered on booking save
- **Password reset** — email link with 1-hour expiry token in DB
- **Cloud hosting** — deploy to Railway or Render, swap H2 → PostgreSQL
- **GDPR consent** — checkbox on register, "Delete My Account" button in profile

PHASE 2 — Sell It (6 weeks – 4 months)

- **SMS reminder** — Twilio API, cron job 24h before booking
- **Stripe deposit** — collect £2–£5 on booking, refund on cancel
- **Analytics dashboard** — Chart.js charts on existing booking data
- **Waitlist** — join queue when full, auto-notify on cancellation

PHASE 3 — Scale It (4–9 months)

- **Multi-café support** — add Cafe entity, each admin sees only their data
- **Subscription billing** — Stripe recurring, Starter / Pro / Chain tiers
- **Interactive floor plan** — drag-and-drop seat map for admin, visual picker for customers
- **QR code check-in** — staff scan, booking auto-marked as arrived

PHASE 4 — Platform (9 months+)

- **Loyalty programme** — visit stamps, rewards, referral system
- **POS integration** — Toast/Square API links orders to bookings
- **WebSockets** — live seat availability updates across devices
- **Calendar sync** — Google/iCal export for customer bookings

HOW-TO How to Implement Phase 1 — Step by Step

1. Email Confirmations (SendGrid) — ~2 days

1. Create a free SendGrid account → get an API key
2. Add `spring-boot-starter-mail` dependency to `pom.xml`
3. Configure SMTP in `application.properties`: host = smtp.sendgrid.net, port 587, username = apikey, password = your-key
4. Create an `EmailService` class that uses `JavaMailSender`
5. In `BookingService.create()` — after saving the booking, call `emailService.sendConfirmation(booking)`
6. Also send email when admin changes status to CONFIRMED

2. Password Reset — ~2 days

1. Add a `resetToken` and `resetTokenExpiry` field to the `User` model
2. New API endpoint: `POST /api/auth/forgot-password` — generates a random token, stores it on the user, sends an email with a reset link
3. New API endpoint: `POST /api/auth/reset-password` — accepts token + new password, validates token is not expired, updates password
4. Add a "Forgot Password?" link to the login page in `auth.html`

3. Cloud Hosting (Railway + PostgreSQL) — ~3 days

1. Create a free account on **Railway.app** (easiest for Spring Boot)
2. Add a PostgreSQL plugin in Railway → it gives you a connection URL automatically

3. In `pom.xml`: replace H2 dependency with `postgresql` driver
4. In `application.properties`: replace H2 URL with the PostgreSQL URL from Railway environment variable
5. Push your backend code to GitHub → connect Railway to your GitHub repo → it deploys automatically
6. Update your frontend `api.js` BASE URL to point to the Railway domain instead of localhost

4. GDPR Compliance — ~2 days

1. Add a checkbox on the register form: "I agree to the Privacy Policy and consent to my data being stored" — required field
2. Store `gdprConsent = true/false` on the User model
3. Add a "Delete My Account" button on the My Bookings page
4. New API endpoint: `DELETE /api/user/me` — deletes the user's account and all their bookings (anonymise booking records rather than hard-delete, to preserve stats)
5. Add a Privacy Policy HTML page — simple text page linked from the footer

POSITIONING

Where CafeBook Sits vs. Competitors (from Exec Summary)

Competitor	Their Price	Zone Selection	Café-Focused	CafeBook Advantage
OpenTable	£250–£550/mo + per-cover fee	✗ No	✗ Restaurant only	10× cheaper. Zone selection. Built for cafés.
Resy	£249–£899/mo flat	✗ No	✗ Upscale dining	Fraction of the cost. Simpler for small cafés.
SevenRooms	£600+/mo custom	✗ Partial	✗ Enterprise only	Not enterprise — accessible to every indie café.
HostMe	Low-cost tiers	✗ No	✗ General venues	Same price range but café-specific with zone picking.
Google Reserve	Free	✗ No	✗ Basic only	Seat selection + admin dashboard + analytics (soon).
CafeBook	**£25–£60/mo**	✓ 6 zones	✓ Built for cafés	**The only affordable, café-first platform with seat selection.**

MEASURE

KPIs to Track — From the Exec Summary

Business Health

- Number of cafés signed up
- Monthly Recurring Revenue (MRR)
- Churn rate (cafés leaving per month)
- Customer Acquisition Cost (CAC)
- Lifetime Value (LTV) per café

Platform Usage

- Total bookings per day / week
- No-show rate (before and after SMS)
- Most popular seating zones
- Peak booking hours by day
- Repeat booking rate per user

Technical Health

- System uptime (target: 99.9%)
- Booking confirmation time (<2 seconds)
- API error rate
- Support ticket volume
- Mobile vs desktop usage split

REVENUE

3-Year Revenue Target (from Exec Summary)

Scenario	Year 1	Year 2	Year 3	What It Takes

Conservative	~£36K	~£121K	~£254K	50 → 100 → 150 cafés at £30–£50/mo avg
Likely	~£133K	~£499K	~£1.33M	100 → 250 → 500 cafés at £50–£100/mo avg
Optimistic	~£399K	~£1.33M	~£3.63M	200 → 500 → 1,000 cafés at £75–£150/mo avg

Realistic first-year goal: 10–20 cafés at £25–£60/month = £3,000–£14,400/year. Small but real. Enough to fund Phase 2 development. The Exec Summary's conservative Year 1 target (£36K) requires 50 cafés — achievable at 6–12 months *after* Phase 1 and Phase 2 are complete.